Long Ballots Reduce Voter Turnout

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Public policy

California Proposition 29, Dialysis Clinic Requirements Initiative (2022)

California Proposition 29, the **Dialysis Clinic Requirements Initiative**, was on the ballot in California as an initiated state statute on November 8, 2022. The ballot measure was **defeated**.

A "**yes**" vote supported this ballot initiative to require dialysis clinics to have at least one physician, nurse practitioner, or physician assistant while patients are being treated; report data on dialysis-related infections; and not discriminate against patients based on the source of payment for care.

A "**no**" vote opposed this ballot initiative to require dialysis clinics to have at least one physician, nurse practitioner, or physician assistant while patients are being treated; report data on dialysis-related infections; and not discriminate against patients based on the source of payment for care.

California Proposition 29

Election date
November 8, 2022

Topic
Healthcare

Status
Defeated

Gary Kremen for Water District Director
September 29, 2022 ·

Proud to be rated 100% by Planned Parenthood Advocates Mar Monte!

rebecca-eisenberg
November 3, 2022 1:04 am at 1:04 am

rebecca4water2.com/endorsements

Sole endorsement by:
The Mercury News &
Los Altos Town Crier
Plus:
Santa Clara County League of Conservation Voters
100% Planned Parenthood Rating

Preview

1. Longer ballots reduce voter turnout
   - 5-6 additional contests $\rightarrow$ 1% (pp) decrease in turnout
   - Turnout, not roll-off

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2. Effect most concentrated in less educated areas, among younger and non-D/R individuals
3. Effect most concentrated on local direct democracy, education, and special districts

Data

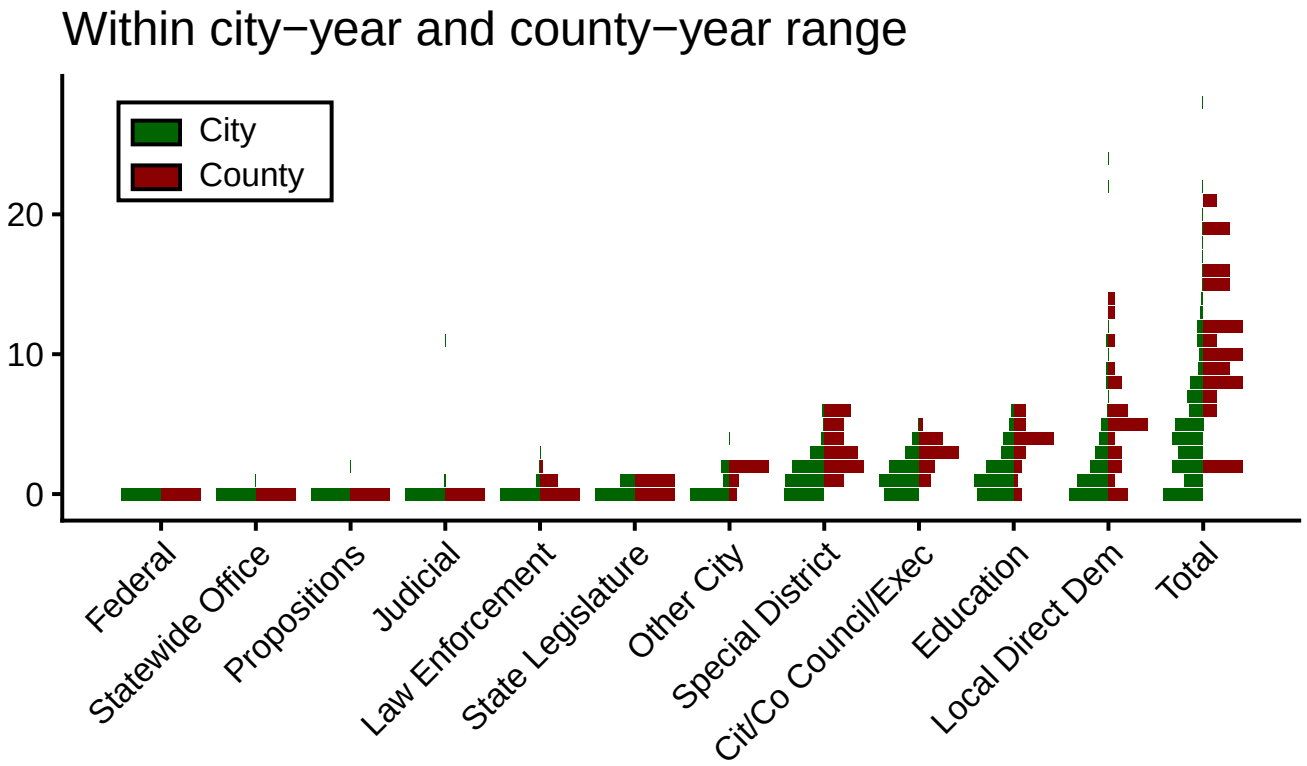
- 8 California counties
- 2016-2020 general elections
- individual level data on ballot length and turnout
  - Data from L2, CA voter file, county by-precinct results, geocode addresses → merge w/ yearly precinct data

→ For everyone continuously living in these 8 counties, I know how long their ballot was each year and whether they voted

- 4.75 Mil reg voters yearly (x3 for N)

Data

- TWFE DiD w/ individual and city-time or county-time FE
  - $$Turnout_{it} = \beta * length_{it} + \omega_{tc} + \alpha_i + \epsilon \quad (1)$$



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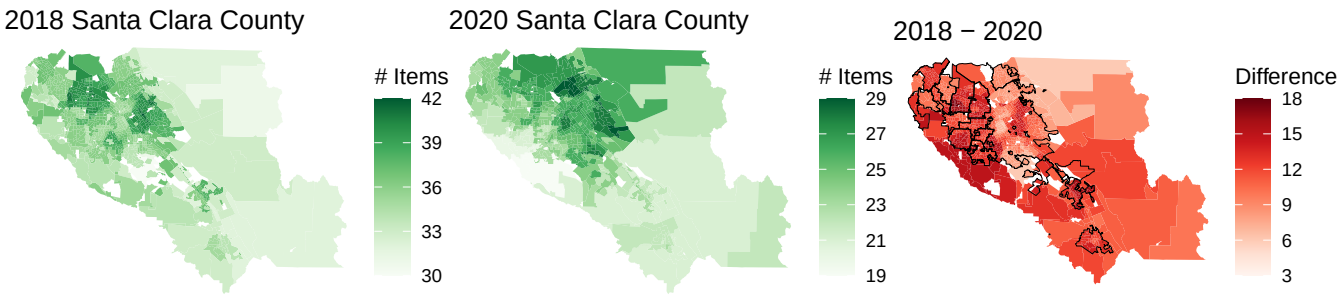

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How does this work?

- In California, everyone mailed ballot since 2020; before 2020 a majority of people were permanently mailed ballots
  - $\sim$18% of US population in mail voting states; 29% of Americans return mail ballots
- With mail ballot: receive ballot $\rightarrow$ observe effort needed to vote $\rightarrow$ decide to vote
  - Out of VBM: go to polling place $\rightarrow$ observe effort needed to complete ballot & roll off on unknown races $\rightarrow$ use this info to decide to vote in $t + 1$

Longer ballots reduce turnout

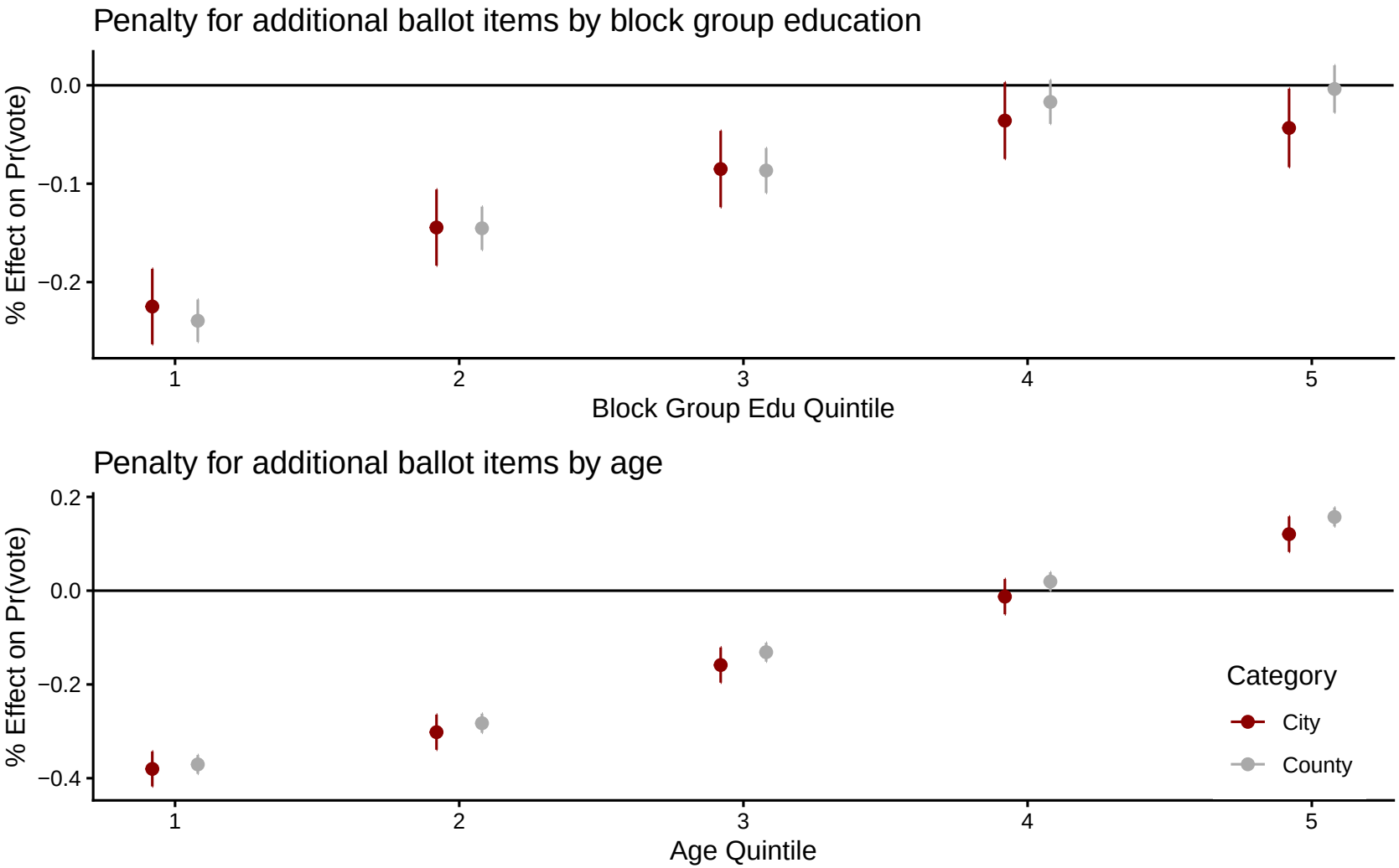
- Individuals with more contests on the ballot are less likely to turn out to vote

	Probability Turnout (0-100%)	
	(1)	(2)
Ballot items	−0.192	−0.172
	(0.020)	(0.011)
Geo-Time FE	City-year	County-year
Individual FE	X	X
N	12719910	14231726

Standard errors clustered by precinct-year and individual.

- San Diego county 2018 75th - 25th percentile = 9 contests

Heterogeneous effects - age and education



Heterogeneous effects - party

	Prob Turnout (0-100%)	
	(1)	(2)
Items×Democrat	−0.160	−0.143
	(0.020)	(0.011)
Items×Repubublican	−0.123	−0.091
	(0.020)	(0.011)
Items×Non-partisan/Third Party	−0.279	−0.263
	(0.020)	(0.011)
Data	All	All
Geo-Time FE	City-year	County-year
Individual FE	X	X
N	12719910	14231726

Standard errors clustered by precinct-year and individual.

By office type

	Probability Turnout (0-100%)	
Council/Exec contests	0.204	0.148
	(0.049)	(0.033)
Education contests	−0.106	−0.249
	(0.034)	(0.025)
Special districts contests	−0.742	−0.573
	(0.052)	(0.035)
Local direct dem contests	−0.047	−0.099
	(0.055)	(0.018)
Other city contests		0.171
		(0.059)
Geo-Time FE	City-year	County-year
Individual FE	X	X
N	12719910	14231726

Standard errors clustered by precinct-year and individual.

Wrapping up

- Political scientists spend a lot of time thinking about what impedes people from voting.
- Need to consider the act of voting itself
  - Voting is higher effort $\rightarrow$ inequalities in who votes
  - Not just a California problem
  - Policy: question the nature of very multilayered governance and expanding democratic burdens

AUPD

- Impressive data collection
- Much needed RHS
- I like:
  - City selection and scale
  - Means of automating
  - Written with clarity
  - Preemption rarely discussed in local politics but this really sold me on the idea that this is a very important component

Selection of issues

- others: don't capture "specific issues cities choose to address or the concrete policy tools they deploy in doing so" ; yours: "grounded in what city gvts actually do"
- Much more clarity in how they were chosen
- Much more justification on why these should be the issues you focus on
- Are these policies central to municipal policy?
- Do these items capture a good % of the policies that cities create?
- Why does policy arise? (and why might some cities be "absent" on a policy)
- What are people going to do with this nice dataset?

More scattered thoughts

- Preemption as a core feature? or as a separate section or even paper? (regardless, more cause-and-effect thinking about preemption)
- How hard to get some more granularity in policy?
- Test-retest on LLMs
- Analysis section
  - this is where you want to deliver a punch
  - "whether D or R cities adopt system diff portfolios," "responsive"
  - My takeaway: a lot of city policies are pretty partisan (but re: previous page)
  - Fig 5/derivative really weird to think through generally (+ CI in Fig 4?)
  - Spec w/o controls
    - suburban vs urban
  - Could ask if city vote choice is more explanatory than pop, income, city budget
- Oversells temporal breadth (not a panel)

Brazilian SDGs

Another great example of bridging elections and policy in the study of cities

- Comprehensive data on Brazilian municipalities and policies they have influence over
- Build a nuanced take about the importance of partisanship and ideology in municipalities
- Clear and honest about findings and limitations

Brazilian SDGs

Predisposed toward finding a null?

- RDD
- 1 year of data
- Long-term capital projects: sewer and water expansion, electricity grid and hardening, trffic, substandard living conditions
- Enough of a time lag between 2020 (October) election, getting seated in office, and 2023 atlas?
- If the SE were smaller, would the framing totally change?
- **Strengthens believability if patterns also absent in descriptive data** (including after some controls)

More scattered thoughts

- Additional context on SDGs: do governments care about them? What cities
- Some additional context on federal spending for municipal responsibilities
- Some additional context on veto players in cities: do mayors have to defer to higher level preemption? municipal-level legislative bodies?
- Sensitivity on categorizations
- Streamline literature and make the distinction in between your theory and literature perspectives more clear

Fiscal policy

- Addresses a massive issue in local politics where we mostly study medium and large cities
- Actually kind of provocative: partisanship matters (sometimes) even in tiny cities, but matters below typical political science cutoffs as well
- Base product more usable than MRP in smaller municipalities

Fiscal policy

- Finding: Partisanship-fiscal policy link is strongest in bigger cities, but still persists in very small cities

Responsiveness

- Dependent on understanding the preferences of partisans
- Requires some type of ID to show party moves first

Nationalization vs responsiveness and framing

- Not an either/or and depends on what you find later
- Nat'l of preferences and responsiveness: knowing preferences
- Nat'l of policy: what you show + maybe over-time
  - But framing around this will invoke Q about nat'l of preferences; overall framing should be driven by follow ups
- incorporation of density, urbanicity as drivers of fiscal policy and citizen wants

Fiscal policy

- Is there more error in imputed party in smaller municipalities?
- If this isn't trying to be a causal story, is TWFE buying much?
  - What types of cities actually encounter meaningful Δ Republican?
- Cluster by state/county?
- Functional form robust? As a $\%\Delta$ in spending/revenue?
- Government form stuff very interesting but somewhat besides the points